

Module 02: Agents — The Felt Sense of Being One Who Acts

Learning Objectives

1. Describe how the **sense of agency** — the felt experience of being the author of one's actions — arises from interoceptive and proprioceptive prediction within the active inference framework.
2. Explain the distinction between **minimal** (pre-reflective) and **narrative** (reflective) senses of agency, drawing on Shaun Gallagher's phenomenological analysis.
3. Analyze how the body's generative model constructs the feeling of "I can" — the somatic apprehension of one's own action capacities.
4. Recognize disruptions of felt agency (in trauma, dissociation, or neurological conditions) as failures of interoceptive self-modeling.

Introduction

Reach out and pick up the nearest object. Now notice: you did not merely observe your hand moving — you felt yourself moving it. There was an unmistakable quality of authorship, a somatic sense that this action originated in you. This felt agency is so constant, so pervasive, that we notice it only when it breaks down — when a limb moves involuntarily, when actions feel alien, when the body seems to act without the self's consent.

The felt sense of agency is more than a cognitive attribution. It is a bodily experience, grounded in the predictive relationship between motor intentions and their sensory consequences. When I reach for a glass, my generative model predicts the proprioceptive and tactile feedback that reaching will produce. When those predictions are confirmed, the action feels like mine. When they are violated — when the hand does not move as expected, or moves when I did not intend it — the sense of agency fractures. Active inference reveals agency not as a metaphysical given but as an ongoing inferential achievement of the embodied self.

Key Concepts

1. The Comparator Model of Agency

The classical account of agency (Blakemore, Wolpert, & Frith, 2002) proposes that the brain compares predicted sensory consequences of action (the **effference copy**) with actual sensory feedback. A match produces the sense of agency; a mismatch produces the sense of external causation. Active inference deepens this comparator model: the felt sense of agency arises when motor prediction errors are minimal — when the body's generative model accurately predicts the sensory flow of its own actions. Agency is not a separate faculty but an emergent property of accurate embodied prediction.

2. Gallagher's Minimal and Narrative Agency

Shaun Gallagher (2000) distinguishes between the **sense of ownership** (feeling that this body is mine) and the **sense of agency** (feeling that I am the author of this action). Both are pre-reflective — they do not require explicit self-reflection but are built into the structure of embodied experience. In the felt sense framework, the sense of ownership corresponds to the body's systemic self-model (Module 01), while the sense of agency corresponds to the motor-predictive dimension: the body's implicit knowledge that it is the source of its own movements.

3. "I Can" — The Somatic Horizon of Possibility

Phenomenologist Maxine Sheets-Johnstone describes the primordial sense of agency as the feeling of "I can" — the body's pre-reflective apprehension of its own movement capacities. Before any specific action, there is a felt horizon of what this body can do: reach, grasp, step, turn. In active inference, this horizon corresponds to the agent's **policy space** — the set of available action sequences, each evaluated by expected free energy. The felt sense of "I can" is the somatic experience of having policies available — the bodily readiness that precedes and enables specific action selection.

4. Disrupted Agency: Trauma and Dissociation

In trauma, the felt sense of agency can be profoundly disrupted. A survivor of chronic abuse may experience actions as happening to them rather than being generated by them — a dissociative fragmentation of the agent-self. In active inference terms, trauma produces a chronic mismatch between motor predictions and sensory outcomes: the agent learned, under conditions of helplessness, that its actions do not reliably produce expected consequences. The generative model's confidence in its own motor predictions collapses, and with it, the felt sense of being one who can act. Recovery involves rebuilding this predictive confidence — slowly re-establishing the link between intention, action, and outcome.

5. Embodied Agency and Autonomic Regulation

Agency is not limited to voluntary skeletal movement. The felt sense includes a dimension of **autonomic agency** — the body's capacity to regulate its own internal states. When you take a deep breath to calm yourself, you are exercising interoceptive agency: using voluntary motor action to shift autonomic states, thereby updating the body's predictions about its own internal milieu. Thomas Fuchs emphasizes that this autonomic dimension is the deepest layer of agency — the body's ongoing, largely silent self-regulation that keeps the organism viable.

Active Inference Connection

In active inference, an agent is defined not by consciousness or rationality but by the presence of a Markov blanket and the capacity to minimize free energy through action. The felt sense of agency is the phenomenological correlate of this formal definition: it is what it feels like to be a system that acts on the world to confirm its own predictions. Every action — from a deliberate reach to an involuntary sigh — is an inference about what the body should do next, evaluated against the expected sensory consequences. Agency, in this framework, is not the cause of action but its experiential texture.

Experiential Applications

- **Practice — Attending to the Emergence of Action:** Before performing a simple action (standing up, reaching for a cup), pause and notice the moment just before the action

begins. Can you detect the felt intention — the somatic "leaning toward" — that precedes the movement? This pre-motor felt sense is your generative model preparing its motor predictions, setting up the sensory expectations against which the action's unfolding will be compared.

- **Case Study — Alien Hand Syndrome:** In this rare neurological condition following callosotomy or stroke, one hand performs purposeful actions that the patient does not experience as self-initiated. The hand may grasp objects, unbutton clothing, or interfere with the other hand's actions. The patient reports that the hand "has a mind of its own." In active inference terms, the motor predictions generated for the alien hand are disconnected from the unified self-model, producing actions without the corresponding proprioceptive predictions that would generate the felt sense of agency.

Cross-References

- **Module 01 (Systems):** The systemic self provides the foundation on which felt agency is constructed.
- **Module 03 (Perception):** Examines how the agent's felt sense shapes what and how it perceives.
- **Module 05 (Action):** Extends the sense of agency into the specific mechanisms of somatic action and motor expression.

Summary

The felt sense of agency — being one who acts — is not a metaphysical given but an ongoing inferential achievement of the embodied self. It arises from the predictive relationship between motor intentions and sensory consequences, grounded in the body's generative model of its own action capacities. When predictions match outcomes, actions feel like ours; when they diverge, agency fractures. This module reveals agency as the lived experience of active inference: the body continuously predicting, acting, and confirming its own existence as an agent in the world.